

Attention! Read out loud

All Web sites instruct using audio-visual methods that makes it easier to grasp pronunciation as well as the script. The Web sites also offer useful links to help you learn about a country, its culture and the language.

The basic tips of learning any language remain the same—read out aloud, converse in the language as often as possible and diligently practice all the exercises listed with every lesson.

Of course, you have the added advantage of learning at a pace that you're comfortable with—either as slowly as

possible, or skim over the easy bits and get your hands dirty with the really tough stuff. This all depends on how badly we want to learn a language. Some of us might need the goading of a teacher, prodding us reluctantly along the learning curve—in which case, learning online might be a problem.

Just try and remember what Nelson Mandela, former South African President, once said, "If you talk to a man in a language he understands, that goes to his head. If you talk to him in his language, it goes to his heart!"

Language exchange

Every action has an equal and opposite reaction! Newton's third law of Languages? It sure seems like that at <http://www.mylanguageexchange.com>.

The concept is simple yet brilliant! The site uses language exchange to teach people languages. For example, a person whose native language is French, can team up with a Hindi speaking user. For half the time they interact per day, they speak in French, the other half is in Hindi. This is called the Cormier method of language exchange, used in schools in Canada. This method is named after Helene Cormier who came up with it way back in 1998. She conducted language workshops at the Club d'échange linguistique de Montréal language school (CELM) in Canada for over 3 years.

The Web site even recommends creating pen pals for beginners and has voice chats for advanced learners.

Conventional tools of learning new languages may have a charm of their own. But it is time to move over stacks of books, pens and the desk. The desktop is here for a whole new way of learning a language—using the Internet. 

APARNA KRISHNAKUMAR

aparna_krishnakumar@thinkdigit.com



MyLanguageExchange.com features the Cormier method of language exchange, used in schools in Canada

to familiarise yourself with grammar, pronunciations and an exhaustive Marathi word list.

Another Web site worth visiting is www.ukindia.com. Though it's targeted at expatriates settled abroad, the site is really useful. It uses both English and the regional language to make things more comfortable for you. You can learn Tamil, Urdu, Hindi, Punjabi, Gujarati, Bengali and Sanskrit.

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